

RAVI S SAHNI



BANDEEP SINGH



REUBEN SINGH

8. MITTAL, NANDAN NILEKANI, RAHUL BAJAJ, ANIL K. GUPTA AND AMAR SINGH; 9. PAWAN MUNJAL WITH GODREJ AND BRIJ MOHAN MUNJAL; 10. MUSHARRAF AND MALIK

11. MUKHERJEE WITH VILLEPIN; 12. YOGI DEVESHWAR AND N.K. SINGH



HEMANT CHAWLA



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everywhere, whether it was the 16-year-old grandmaster Parimarjan Negi, who took off from his Class X board exam preparations to meet Kasparov or Kumar Mangalam Birla, who wanted to meet the Dalai Lama. His Holiness who had driven five hours to Pathankot and chartered a flight from there, to make it in time for the inaugural session.

Despite Nouriel Roubini's prescription of doom, spirits were afloat. Pranab Mukherjee was punctual as usual and spent the waiting time talking to a small group of agog listeners about the problems of running a coalition. Former French prime minister Dominique de Villepin wished him the best of luck for the forthcoming elections, while also managing to find time to meet up with friends from his days in

the Capital as deputy chief of the French mission. West Bengal MP Dinesh Trivedi wanted Union Minister Murli Deora to send a message to Rahul Gandhi about seat sharing with Trinamool Congress. Musharraf wanted to catch up with his past and despite strict security, managed to slip out late at night on Day 2, to visit part of the walled city where he was born. A repeat visit the next day was so crowded that his security escort lost his shoe.

The former Pakistan president was so overwhelmed by the hospitality that he said he had put on several kilos during the visit. He loved the gala dinner cuisine so much that he ordered a repeat of the moong dal halwa the next day. If only it meant sweeter India-Pakistan relations. ■